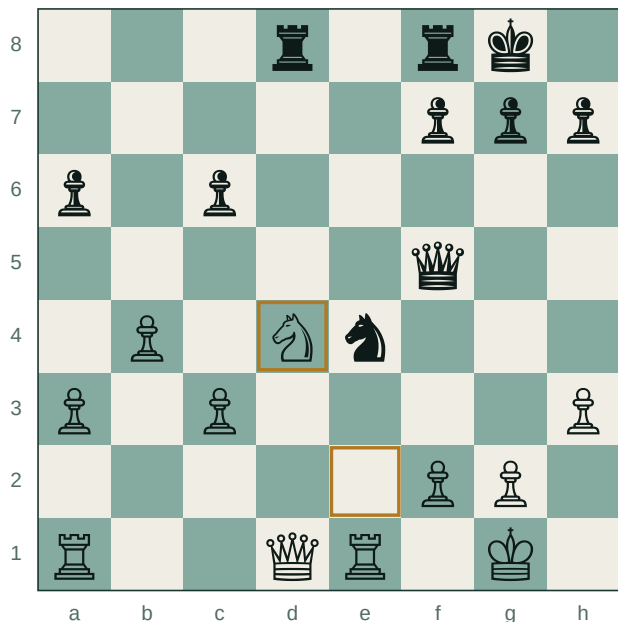


Capture the defender: Black, move 21

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 21.Nxd4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

21...Qxf2+ 22. Kh1 Nxc3 23. Qf3 Qxd4

21...Qxf2+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. From f2 it attacks king on g1, rook on e1 and knight on d4. Recorded reply: **22.Kh1**.

22...Nxc3 The knight captures the pawn on c3. Recorded reply: **23.Qf3**.

23...Qxd4 The queen captures the knight on d4.

At the end, nominal material is White 23 / Black 27 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +5: the balance goes from -1 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.